sole right to sell alcohol, it has also led to the state's increasing dependence on liquor revenue. According to experts, alcohol addiction in Tamil Nadu, aided by state patronage of burgeoning TASMAC outlets, is now assuming dire proportions. More importantly, TASMAC has been unable to curb clandestine production of hooch and illicit liquor. Former Tamil Nadu Director General of Police Sylendra Babu has pointed out that an alarming 140,649 cases were registered in connection with spurious liquor production and sale in 2022 in the state.

A recent official communication from TASMAC managing director S. Visakan to district managers and zonal officers also reveals a rotting innard—consumers being charged extra, expenses like rent and electricity charges shouldered by staff, and bribes allegedly paid to police officers and politicians. Also clouding the chain of accountability is the fact that the government does not divulge the amount of liquor procured from private breweries and distilleries and the prices at which they are supplied to TASMAC.

Furthermore, the TASMAC Employees Union alleges that some workers collect money from outlets for prohibition and excise minister S. Muthuswamy. On July 17, the minister stated that people who consume alcohol in the morning are mostly involved in physical labour and should not be called 'drunkards'. He also suggested that TASMAC outlets be opened in the morning for such workers' benefit.

The BJP has long been protesting against TASMAC and the state government's liquor policy. Annamalai's determined campaign against it—as he travels through all 234 assembly constituencies over the next 200 days to expand the saffron party's footprint—may yet stir a debate. There are many who argue that attempts to limit alcohol consumption and sale would hit the Tamil Nadu exchequer, impacting its ability to fund social welfare schemes. "Such arguments reinforce the need for urgent and decisive action...the administration has come to believe its need to perpetuate, promote and enable this social evil in the name of shoring up revenues," says Annamalai in a riposte.

Accordingly, the BJP dossier includes steps to stem the alleged irregularities in TASMAC (see *Agenda for a Dry Future*). "Tamil Nadu's infamous record of devising scientific methods of corruption proves to be a greater threat to the economy than the closing down of a few thousand liquor outlets. This deadly cocktail of corruption, alcoholism and political scheming has to end for the state to prosper and thrive," says Annamalai.

"The expectation is not for reforms but for reintroducing total prohibition, especially since the ruling DMK had promised it before the 2016 assembly polls," says political commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy. TASMAC was brought under full state control under the AIADMK government of Jayalalithaa in 2003.

"If the state restricts the sale of liquor, the first victims will be the politicians and corrupt bureaucracy, not the people or the state exchequer," says political analyst Ramu Manivannan. "The idea of revenue loss is a fear of uncertainty and unpreparedness to explore leasing and licensing the manufacturing with control and accountability." He believes that only phased prohibition—creating TASMAC-free zones, with a 10 per cent reduction in the number of shops as well as working hours, year on year—could help the state overcome its alcohol problem. ■

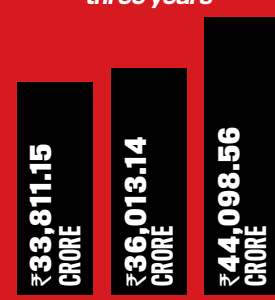
AGENDA FOR A DRY FUTURE

The BJP has proposed a slew of measures for phased prohibition

- Declare 45 days during the Tamil months of Karthigai and Margazhi as dry days
- Reduce operating hours of TASMAC outlets, making it from 2 pm to 7 pm
- Ensure availability of 'light liquor' such as 46 listed brands of beer
- Provide a customer identification number to monitor drinking patterns, identify vulnerable groups. This could then serve as data to plan rehabilitation programmes
- Shut all 3,240 bars and 5,380 liquor retail vending outlets within a three-year timeframe

RAISING THE BAR

Increase in TASMAC revenue over the past three years



THE BJP URGES THE TN GOVT TO MAKE GOOD LIQUOR REVENUE LOSSES FROM MINING OR DEVELOPING THE ELECTRONICS INDUSTRY